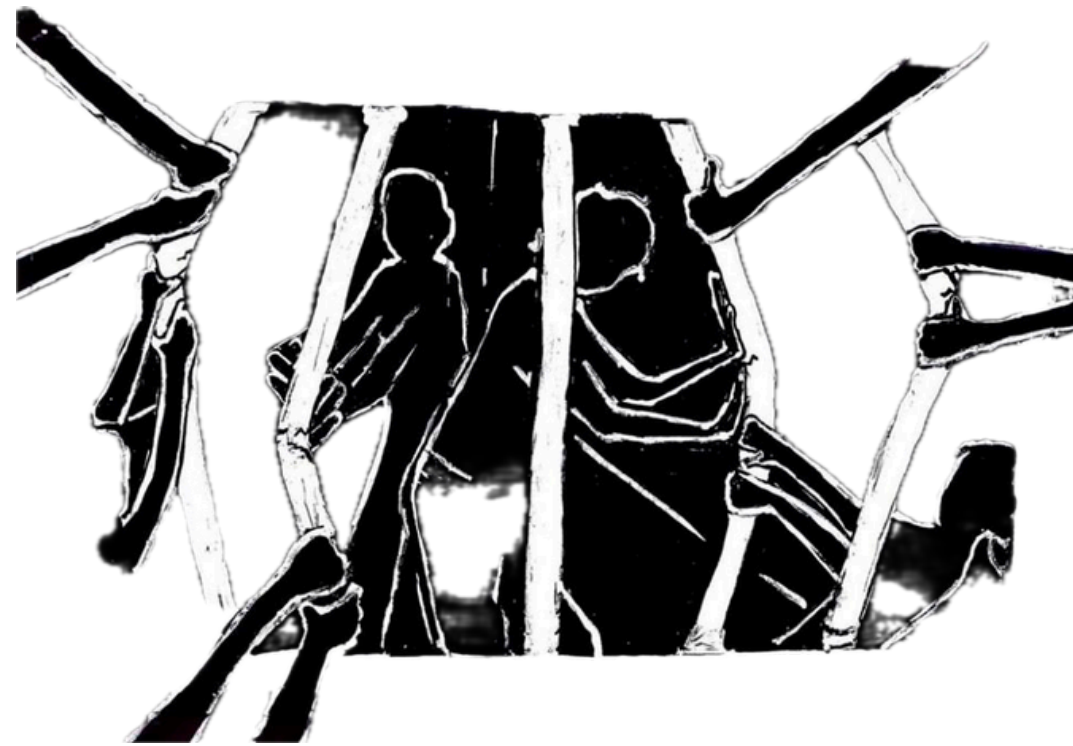




MUTUAL AID AND ABOLITION



GUIDING IDEAS

Prisons are inextricably linked to racism and capitalism, which are themselves intertwined.

Newton argues that there are two types of American prisoners: the “illegitimate capitalist,” who seeks to acquire goods and profit, but does so in ways that society has deemed “illegitimate,” and the political prisoner, who rejects the legitimacy of capitalist society. He explains that the modern “Big House” prison cannot rehabilitate either prisoner, the illegitimate capitalist because he will simply conform to the ways of the prison while incarcerated and return to his ways post-incarceration, and the political prisoner because he rejects the society to which he is supposedly being rehabilitated.

“One has a greater chance of going to jail or prison if one is a young black man than if one has actually a law-breaker” (Davis 1988 367).

According to Ruth Wilson Gilmore, prison expansion in the 1990s in CA was a reaction to a political economic crisis, and aimed to solve issues of surplus labor, capital, state capacity, and land. These issues were a product of a capitalist economy, largely dependent on military spending. This ‘surplus labor’ largely comprised Black individuals, who were funnelled into prisons (Lecture 3/31).

GUIDING IDEAS

- To many people, the project of prison abolition feels daunting
- I am interested in learning about abolition efforts that feel tangible
- Abolitionists including Angela Davis and Mariame Kaba have spoken about the process of *decarceration* as a step towards prison abolition

“Rather, positing decarceration as our overarching strategy, we would try to envision a continuum of alternatives to imprisonment-demilitarization of schools, revitalization of education at all levels, a health system that provides free physical and mental care to all, and a justice system based on reparation and reconciliation rather than retribution and vengeance”
(Davis 2003 107)

HOW DOES THE PRACTICE OF MUTUAL AID CONTRIBUTE TO THE PROJECT OF PRISON ABOLITION?

THEORY/CONTEXT

- Research about the concept of mutual aid (Kropotkin, Spade)
- Understanding the relevance of mutual aid in the historical context of organizing in the US

METHOD

- Understanding mutual aid as prefigurative to abolition, contributing to decarceration
- Mutual aid as a collective, grassroots practice that can be facilitated by regular people (Simonson)

APPLICATIONS

- Mutual aid outside of the prison
- Mutual aid as a practice within the prison
- Mutual aid during the “re-entry” process

Mutual aid involves
consciousness-raising
and mobilization tactics

The diagram consists of three dotted lines connecting the sections. One line starts from the bottom of the 'THEORY/CONTEXT' section and points towards the central text. Another line starts from the bottom of the 'METHOD' section and points towards the central text. A third line starts from the bottom of the 'APPLICATIONS' section and points towards the central text.

WHAT IS MUTUAL AID?

- The term 'mutual aid' was first officially introduced by Peter Kropotkin
 - Challenges Darwin's evolutionary theory of "survival of the fittest"
 - Argues that animals and humans have *always* depended on mutual aid
 - Anarchist-communist
- Dean Spade envisions mutual aid as a way forward in the transition from "undemocratic infrastructure" to "sustainable, regenerative ways of living" (20)
 - Solidarity, not charity
 - Mutual aid can produce cultural and material transformation

- Loïc Wacquant understands prison and welfare as opposite sides of the same coin
 - Thus, mutual aid (which is rooted in *collective* care and opposes the *individualistic* nature of capitalism) is a more effective approach to decarceration and eventually, abolition



MUTUAL AID AND THE BPP

OUTSIDE OF THE PRISON

- Black Panther Party Free Breakfast Program (Potorti)
 - Late 1960s
 - Ensured the physical survival of Black children
 - Planted seeds of anti-capitalist, abolitionist ideas (consciousness-raising) → mobilization
 - Scaling
- Next Steps
 - I am curious about how mutual aid that provides material support and cultivates community might contribute to decarceration; if people benefit from mutual aid, are they less likely to have to rely on “illegal” ways of procuring money, food, etc.?



MUTUAL AID WITHIN THE PRISON

- Evident in every day acts of care (Davis and Fayter, Meyers)
- Challenges the isolating nature of the prison (Davis and Fayter)
- Ensures the survival of incarcerated individuals (Davis and Fayter, Meyers)
- Encourages the formation of friendship and community
- Next Steps
 - I would like to know more about how mutual aid within prisons is capable of radicalizing and mobilizing individuals
 - Is this political consciousness only cultivated through more formalized networks, or can it be facilitated through these “everyday acts of care?”
- Huey P. Newton underscores the prison’s aims to preserve capitalism
 - The prison can be understood as the last line of defense protecting capitalism
 - If mutual aid, a practice that defies the competitive individualism inherent to capitalism, is practiced *inside* the prison, it has the potential to be a hugely disruptive force

MUTUAL AID DURING ‘RE-ENTRY’

“Giving Back and Getting Something Back: The Role of Mutual-Aid Groups for Individuals in Recovery From Incarceration, Addiction, and Mental Illness”

Bellamy, Rowe, Benedict, and Davidson

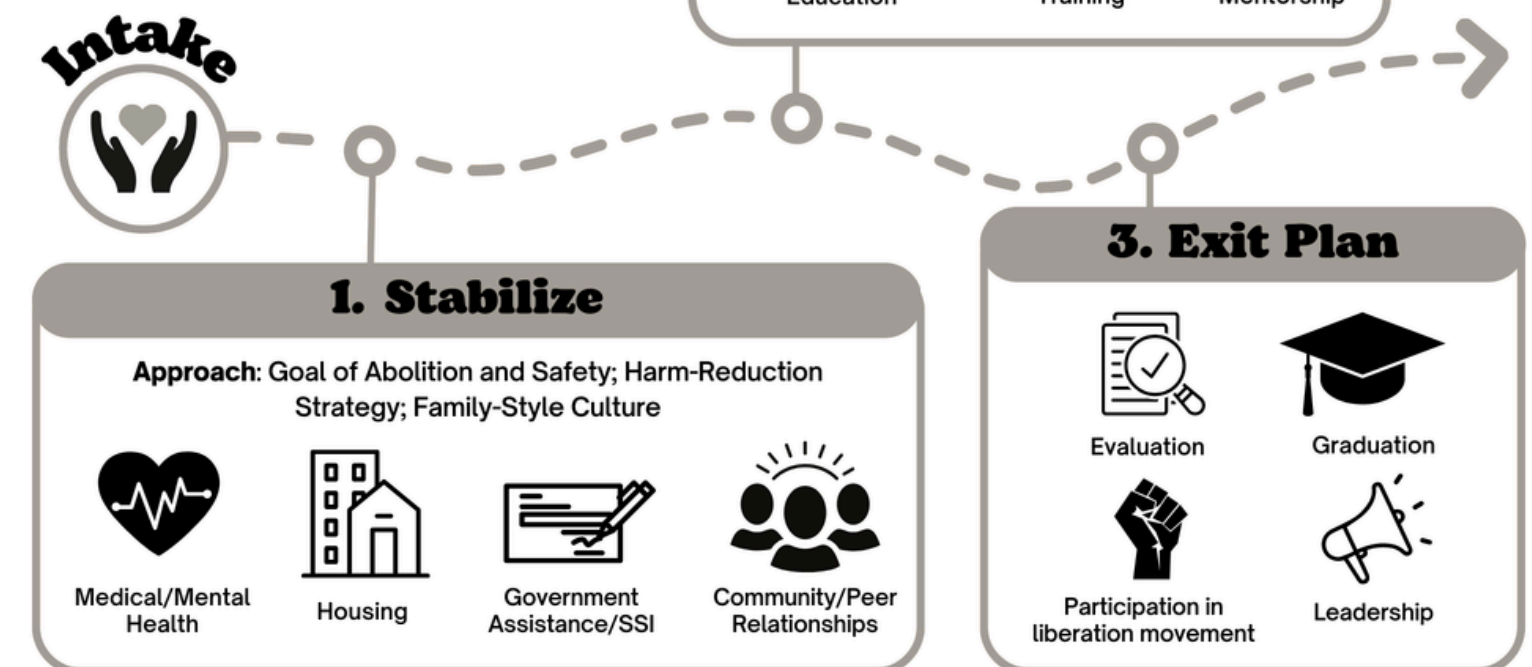
- A study that developed an educational program and associated mutual aid discussion group for individuals with mental illness and/or experiences with substance abuse who also had a history with incarceration
- Found that the mutual aid group builds trust, fosters interpersonal skills, and facilitates community

Example of a ‘Re-Entry’ Program Rooted in Mutual Aid

MELENIE ELENEKE GRASSROOTS RE-ENTRY/ SOCIO-ECONOMIC JUSTICE PROGRAM

Members connect with TI Justice Project through many avenues and means. Sometimes we are able to stop the harms impacting our community before formal criminalization, policing, or incarceration, however we frequently hear from our community once they are already system involved.

This visual of our re-entry work demonstrates that TGJJP builds programs from the point of contact to intervene in the immediate harms and crises of our community while working to collectivize and politicize in the process.



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